DREAMCATCHER

A science fiction story

Prologue

The sound of a burning hearth was the first thing Ludwig heard. It was humming quietly and sometimes making a loud cracking noise, as if the flames were sharp teeth biting through the logs, chewing them with vigor and satisfaction. It made Ludwig hungry, as he sat in an old leather armchair curled under a blanket.

It was a cold winter night in Norway, the winds howling outside the house walls, and Ludwig knew that the trip to the cold kitchen to get some food would drain all the warmth and happiness out of him. Thankfully, he did not have to make it, as he suddenly found he was already holding a tuna sandwich in his right hand. It is a very good feeling indeed, to recognize a hard problem and then watch it unravel all by itself. Sadly, though, Ludwig's time in this world was nearly running out, and there was an alarm at the back of his mind ringing louder and ever louder. And he knew that he would soon wake up and leave the house and struggle against the frosty winds on his way to school. It was unfair, terribly unfair, that circumstances should have aligned so perfectly, only for Ludwig to be drawn out of this dream and into mundane reality, where nothing was ever perfect. Just before fading away, the remains of Ludwig's consciousness were filled with anger and defiance, and he willed only for one thing—to keep the sandwich, the gift of this merciful world.

But it was too late. Sharply Ludwig opened his eyes and sat up in his bed, all sleepiness drained out of him. The memories from the dream were still clear in his mind, but now they seemed fake and impossible. Ludwig's house had neither a hearth, nor any leather chairs. Feeling slightly disappointed, Ludwig reached out with his right hand to silence the alarm that kept ringing, but—oh wonder!—his hand was holding a tuna sandwich, just as luscious as he'd remembered it. He turned it over and saw that it was just a regular sandwich, yet somehow it felt both alien and familiar at the same time. Ludwig could have pondered the reasons and consequences of what had just happened, but instead he did what any self-respecting 9-year-old would do—he quickly ate the sandwich and started packing his bag for school.

Not long after, a similar event occurred, and this time it shook humanity to its very core. A young forensic analyst named Paul Mason finally got home at eleven p.m. after a hellish day at work. He had just moved to South Carolina, and he had just examined his first crime scene.

He went into this line of work because he had always been good at noticing details, and his life had always felt too ordinary, so he had decided to spice it up by connecting his career with crime. However, after seeing the site of a gruesome murder deep in the national forest, after methodically examining the layer of blood splashed over the bushes, after counting the poor woman's broken teeth and noticing her torn clothing and the bruising around her crotch, and the marks of dried tears around her dead eyes, he was starting to seriously doubt his career choices.

Paul could only console himself by thinking of the forest. What was this murder, but a tiny speck of crimson-red death in a vast, boundless sea of green growing life? As long as those mighty trees were standing tall and strong, he thought, he could also find the strength to do this job. Because he had chosen it, and because someone had to do it.

Feeling broken but resolute, Paul lay down and closed his eyes, immediately falling into

sleep. The next moment, he was back in the forest. He could not really understand why he had come back, because the body, the signs of struggle, the broken branches and stumped grass—everything was mysteriously gone, just like nothing had ever happened. *Where's the blood?* Paul thought, *did a rain wash it all away?*

As he walked around, he noticed the wind growing stronger and the daylight growing dimmer, the clouds above getting darker. Then the first drop of rain landed on his open palm, and it felt like a knife stabbing into his soul, because it was the crimson-red color of blood. Then another red droplet landed on his shoulder, then two more on his forearm, and a feeling of primal dread slowly crept into Paul. He could hear the trees croaking and shaking, as if trying to uproot themselves and run away, all to escape this rain which was Death itself. He could feel the rusty smell of blood as it started to pour from above.

Soon the whole sky was red, and Paul was red, and all around the green treetops and the bushes and the grass were all drinking this red poison and becoming the same shade of crimson-red. And Paul knew that they would never change back, that the horrible red drops had seeped and soaked into the trees and stained their very DNA. He knew that the green color of life and health would never be seen again.

Paul woke up at nine a.m., his bedroom sheets drenched in sweat. They were soaking wet, but they were green, and Paul let out a sigh of relief. It was all a dream. Then Paul thought about the previous day and the murder, and felt like shit again. *At least the sky ain't raining blood,* he thought with a thin smile.

Then he opened the window curtains to let in the morning sun, and his smile instantly disappeared, and his momentary relief turned to ash. The trees in the yard had leaves the color of blood, a familiar, but also somewhat alien color.

Six hours before, while it was three a.m. in South Carolina, the time was eight a.m. in Berlin, twelve p.m in Astana, and four p.m. in Tokyo. All around the eastern hemisphere people looked up from their desks, stopped in the streets, left whatever they were doing to watch how all the treetops, the decorative bushes, the lawns, and the house plants were slowly turning crimson-red from top to bottom, as if someone were pouring viscous blood on top of them.

For a few minutes, no one could tear their eyes away from this foreign, yet painfully familiar color. They were like prey that stares in the deadly eyes of a predator, unable to look away and paralyzed by fear.

Chapter 1